

Disease destroyer

The mold was from the penicillium family, so Alexander chose the name “penicillin” for the bacteria-killing chemical it produced. Penicillin destroyed many types of bacteria, including the ones that caused deadly diseases, such as pneumonia, syphilis, and diphtheria. Even better, it didn’t harm human cells, unlike antiseptics.

During World War II, other scientists raced to turn penicillin into a medicine that could be given to humans. Howard Florey and Ernst Chain succeeded, and in 1945, they shared the Nobel Prize with Alexander for the discovery of the world’s first “antibiotic.” Meanwhile, another scientist named Dorothy Hodgkin was trying to figure out the chemical structure of penicillin so that even better medicines could be made.

After World War II, scientists found more natural antibiotics. These have saved millions of lives around the world and are still the main weapon we have against harmful bacteria. Some bacteria have become resistant to antibiotics, so there is an ongoing effort to develop new ones.



I did not invent penicillin. Nature did that. I only discovered it by accident.

Blue-green penicillium molds can grow on food when it rots. We shouldn't eat moldy foods, since many types of mold could be present—including those that can be harmful to humans.